and vehicle washing station are compulsory. Two ODOP (One District, One Product) kiosks must rotate annually on regulated rents to ensure local producers a foothold. Other facilities like electric vehicle charging stations, ATMs and full-fledged clinics will be optional.

A NOTE OF CAUTION

Like with everything else, the success of this policy, too, say experts, will depend on implementation. Ensuring that contractual obligations—especially with regard to land, infrastructure and utilities—are met is essential, says Anjali Nathwani, director, Crisil Market Intelligence & Analytics. She adds oil marketing and food safety approvals to the list, saying, "Resolving bottlenecks will maintain the interest of private investors and ensure long-term success."

Another point of concern is the government's traffic projections. The NITI Aayog, for instance, flagged traffic estimates for two proposed highways this June. On the Mukama to Munger stretch of NH-33 in Bihar, it noted that nearly three-quarters of the vehicles are bikes, auto-rickshaws and tractors, which means service lanes make better sense than widening the road to a six-lane highway. On NH-60 (Nashik-Ahmednagar-Solapur-Akkalkot), the body and the department of expenditure were circumspect about daily traffic more than doubling from 17,000 to 38,000 vehicles. MoRTH, in its defence, cited surveys that showed traffic would shift from NH-48 and NH-52.

That shift, however, is unlikely to happen if there are no WSAs. Truckers, especially, are likely to avoid such routes. "Where will a driver go if they don't get food and drink?" asks J.P. Singla, CEO of the All India Transporters Welfare Association (AITWA). "And who will open WSAs if the cost is so high that truckers cannot afford the services?" AITWA has also red-flagged the link between the absence of amenities and highway accidents—it estimates that 40 per cent of accidents are due to driver fatigue.

It all boils down to footfall, says Zafar Khan, president of the Highways Operators' Association and head of Vertis Infrastructure Trust. "In areas with good footfall, major roads like Delhi–Jaipur, Delhi–Dehradun, Mumbai–Pune, facilities are developing fast. But where there's nothing, for example, in UP, you can go 200 km at a stretch and see absolutely nothing... you feel unsafe. If something happens at 2 am, your only option is to call 1033 and be taken to the toll plaza."

Drivers, though, are availing workarounds. Rest-stops known as 'Apna Ghar' have popped up in 368 locations around the country, set up by oil marketing companies. The night resting facility is cheap— it currently offers 4,611 beds—but CCTVs often don't work, which is a major flaw as trucks often carry goods worth lakhs of rupees. But Jitendra Kushwaha, a driver who threads three states a week, does not mind: "Give me a clean bed, shower, cheap thali, tyre repair service and place to wash my clothes. Price it fairly and keep it open all night. I'll plan my run around that."

For what it's worth, Gadkari is candid about past missteps. "We're reviewing policies, correcting shortcomings and aiming to deliver world-class services. Some developers claim projected traffic hasn't materialised; that's a separate issue, but we must keep trying to improve." That promise is what Indian travellers are banking on—a dignified, safe and comfortable space that gives them a welcome break after hours on the road. ■

NEW POLICY, NEW GOALS

The 2025 draft policy on Wayside Amenities aims to set up 5,000 rest facilities nationally with speedy private investment

RESPONSIBLE AUTHORITY & MODEL

The new policy introduces a new franchise model, managed by National Highway Logistics Management Limited (NHLML), exclusively for development on private land

LAND OWNERSHIP & LEASE

Private landowners must now form a company to act as a franchisee of NHLML. Or they can lease their land to the body for 30 years for an annual Rs 100 fee

LOCATION

Aims for amenities every 30-40 km instead of 40-60 km earlier, with land area varying from 0-2 acres, 2-5 acres or more than 5 acres. The land must have a frontage of 100 metres (50 m in hilly areas). It cannot be within 5 km of a city or town

FINANCES

The franchisee is responsible for financing. A nominal franchise fee of Rs 100 per month is charged by NHLML for the first three years, increasing to Rs 25,000 monthly with annual inflation adjustment

DESIGN

Requires a minimum of 60 per cent open space, but the maximum covered area is capped at 35 per cent. The franchisee must adhere to NHLML's standard layout and design

TERMINATION & LEASE END

Franchise can be terminated for non-compliance with design, poor operation or payment defaults. The lease can be extended after 30 years, else assets handed over to the landowner